

Chapter 155-1

Liang Shi bringing Xu Qingzhu to the set was quite an abrupt action.

Before bringing her, she had of course messaged Gu Yixue first.

Clearly, Gu Yixue was stunned for a moment.

Liang Shi stared at the top of the chat window, watching "Director Gu Yixue" and "The other party is typing" constantly switching back and forth. Finally, Gu Yixue sent two concise words: [Bring her.]

It seemed exactly like a compromise made out of helplessness.

After seeing the message, Xu Qingzhu even said that Gu Yixue was quite nice to her.

Liang Shi nodded: "We probably get along well."

After arriving at the set, everyone cast appraising glances at Xu Qingzhu. Xu Qingzhu remained poised and graceful, letting everyone look.

She even went up to greet Gu Yixue.

Gu Yixue casually glanced over her face. "Quite photogenic."

Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly: "What? Is Director Gu thinking of recruiting me to act?"

"I'll invite you next time there's a suitable role," Gu Yixue said.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Then I'll try my best to cooperate."

From Xu Qingzhu's perspective, it was just a joke; she didn't take it seriously.

This outsider Xu Qingzhu didn't disrupt the crew's original rhythm. As soon as she arrived, Liang Shi was taken away to have her makeup and hair done.

Meanwhile, Sun Chengcheng, who had already finished her makeup and hair and changed into her costume, sidled over and quietly asked Xu Qingzhu: "Were you alright yesterday? I wanted to come find you all, but then I realized I couldn't find you."

Mentioning this made Sun Chengcheng extremely frustrated.

She had originally thought the system had given her such a good opportunity, only to discover she couldn't do anything at all.

After Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu came up from the water, all she could do was hand over a towel, yet Lu Jiayi wouldn't even give her a proper glance.

She was so angry last night she couldn't sleep.

Now she could only continue fawning over Xu Qingzhu. "Was it that little girl who pushed you into the water yesterday? How did you fall in when you were standing perfectly fine?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Not too sure."

Her expression had already turned cold, with an air of—I'm not familiar with you, so why are you still coming to talk to me—impatience.

Sun Chengcheng could feel it too. She figured Liang Shi must have said something to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't had this attitude toward her before.

"What's your relationship with that..." Sun Chengcheng suddenly lowered her voice, "...with Liang Shi?"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu's gaze turned sharp, her tone icy cold: "What does it have to do with you?"

Sun Chengcheng: "..."

Sun Chengcheng put on a troubled expression. After a moment, she bit her lip and leaned in, but Xu Qingzhu shifted to the side to avoid her.

"Miss Sun," Xu Qingzhu said, "this exceeds the appropriate social distance between us."

Sun Chengcheng: "..."

The gazes from the surroundings seemed to be increasing, as if everyone was waiting to watch her make a fool of herself.

Under these circumstances, Sun Chengcheng could only pretend to be calm. "I have something to tell you."

"You can say it," Xu Qingzhu said. "Please maintain your distance. My wife doesn't like people getting too close to me."

Sun Chengcheng: "..."

Sun Chengcheng became anxious. "I'm different from her—I don't even like women!"

Xu Qingzhu drew out her voice, slow and cold: "Oh?"

In a world like this, saying you didn't like women was quite ridiculous.

Most people present wouldn't say they liked men or women; they mostly judged based on ABO dynamics.

Sun Chengcheng also realized her slip of the tongue and immediately corrected herself: "What I mean is I don't have that kind of thought about you. We're just friends."

"I'm sorry," Xu Qingzhu coldly sized her up, "are we friends?"

A light and simple retort, her gaze clear, seemingly just expressing—you're too presumptuous.

This gave Sun Chengcheng a strong sense of defeat.

Under the scrutiny of so many people, she felt utterly embarrassed.

"Yes... I suppose?" Sun Chengcheng said uncertainly.

Before, she had eaten meals with Xu Qingzhu and had afternoon tea together, which really gave her the feeling that she had already won Xu Qingzhu over.

The information had shown that Xu Qingzhu had once been betrayed by a close friend, so she was particularly cautious.

So when Xu Qingzhu treated her to meals and chatted freely with her, she thought she had already entered Xu Qingzhu's heart.

But unexpectedly... Liang Shi appeared out of nowhere.

Sun Chengcheng secretly resented this but couldn't show it on her face, so she could only smile bitterly with helplessness, though this smile was somewhat twisted.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "Do you have anything else to say? If not, I'm leaving."

Sun Chengcheng immediately said: "Yes."

She leaned in and whispered: "The person who had me tell you about Liang He's information back then was this very person. She's full of sweet talk—don't be deceived by her."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Oh."

Her attitude was completely indifferent.

Sun Chengcheng became anxious. "Really! You really shouldn't believe her. She's very good at deceiving people."

"That's quite nice," Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly. "I've been teaching her for so long, and it's finally showing results."

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "My wife can deceive people now. How wonderful."

Sun Chengcheng: "...?"

Chapter 155-2

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During the afternoon filming, Sun Chengcheng was completely out of it. After more than a dozen NGs, Gu Yixue became furious. "Can you fucking film or not? If you can't, let's replace you."

The entire crew fell silent.

No one dared to speak up for Sun Chengcheng at a time like this. When Sun Chengcheng tried to defend herself, before the words even left her mouth, Gu Yixue scolded her: "If you'd used this acting in the drama, you would've fucking made it big ages ago."

Sun Chengcheng's tears hung on her eyelashes, not daring to fall.

A wave of humiliation washed over her.

"Go cool off to the side," Gu Yixue said. "Think carefully about whether you still want to film this. If not, we'll terminate the contract. I won't ask you for breach of contract fees."

"Alright, everyone take a break." Gu Yixue looked toward Liang Shi. "Liang Shi, we'll film your scenes in a bit. Is that okay?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Sure."

All the staff members even walked quietly, afraid of making Gu Yixue angry again.

But Gu Yixue was still dignified enough not to let everyone see her with a cold face. She went outside alone to smoke.

As soon as Gu Yixue left, Sun Chengcheng sat there crying.

The two newcomers, Qi Tang and Tang Zui, stood there stupidly, not knowing whether to go comfort her.

Then Xu Qingzhu called out: "Two little sisters, would you like some milk tea?"

Qi Tang and Tang Zui were both startled: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "The weather is too cold. I'm treating everyone to milk tea."

After she said this, her secretary and assistant came in carrying two large bags of milk tea, then went back to get more.

Everyone in the crew got one; no one was left out.

Even Sun Chengcheng, who had been sitting there crying and feeling ostracized—Xu Qingzhu called out to her in front of everyone: "Who hasn't made mistakes before? Don't feel wronged. Director Gu is doing this for your sake and for the drama's sake. Come have a cup of milk tea to warm up. Don't cry yourself hoarse, or you won't be able to say your lines later."

Her words were impeccable.

But Sun Chengcheng felt even more stifled inside.

Just a moment ago, she said they weren't friends, and now she was doing all this entirely for Liang Shi's sake!

And what about her?

She was nothing but leftover scraps used to make Liang Shi look good.

Sun Chengcheng was so angry she nearly tore the costume she was wearing.

Xu Qingzhu had company matters to attend to afterward. Having been there for less than two hours, she left with her assistant and secretary.

When she was leaving, Liang Shi went outside to see her off.

Xu Qingzhu quietly reminded her: "Don't let her bully you again."

Liang Shi said helplessly: "Can I really fall into the same pit twice?"

"That's hard to say." Xu Qingzhu said: "If you get bullied by her again this time, I'll take it as you liking her."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I definitely don't like her." Liang Shi immediately defended herself. "Don't talk nonsense."

"I don't care." Xu Qingzhu said: "Someone I couldn't even bear to bully got bullied by her, so I'll..."

Liang Shi was amused by her domineering tone. "You'll what?"

"Make her cry even louder than just now."

"What about me?" Liang Shi said. "You won't deal with me?"

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment, then suddenly said seriously: "I can't bear to."

Chapter 155-3

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After being scolded by Gu Yixue, Sun Chengcheng performed well and was particularly well-behaved on set.

It was as if she was holding back a surge of energy, wanting to prove herself to everyone.

Gu Yixue's expression also softened a bit.

As a director, Gu Yixue was indeed qualified.

That day when Sun Chengcheng performed too poorly, she threw a fit in front of everyone. But later when Sun Chengcheng improved, she also praised her in front of everyone, saying she filmed decently and had gotten into the zone.

Xu Qingzhu returned to Haizhou City, spinning like a top every day without rest.

She said she was developing new business and was very busy.

But she never mentioned the nightmares again, even though during their video calls, her condition seemed different from before—she appeared somewhat pale and haggard.

Liang Shi asked if she wasn't resting well.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "The company has been too busy lately."

So whenever there were no night scenes, Liang Shi would drive home.

Even though she had to wake up early the next day.

Xu Qingzhu felt sorry for her. After Liang Shi came home twice, Xu Qingzhu simply moved into her hotel room after work.

The entire crew knew that Liang Shi had brought her wife onto the set.

After getting familiar with the two young girls playing the second female leads, they would bring the two of them along when going out for late-night snacks.

Qi Tang was quieter and relatively shy, while Tang Zui was more talkative.

But ironically, in the drama, they played characters with opposite personalities.

Usually, Tang Zui was more curious about the two of them as a couple. While eating late-night snacks, her little eyes would dart back and forth between them, asking who pursued whom.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Ask Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi said: "I pursued her."

"Never thought Teacher Liang could be so proactive." Tang Zui said: "At first, we thought Teacher Liang was like a Buddha statue—too zen."^1^

Liang Shi was surprised: "Really?"

She thought she had only given Xiao Bai and the others that kind of impression.

Tang Zui nodded vigorously: "And you look gentle, but you keep your distance from everyone. Now we know it's just because we weren't close to you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Throughout the meal, it was almost entirely Tang Zui, this young girl, doing the talking.

Calling her a young girl—actually, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu weren't that much older than them.

Especially Xu Qingzhu, so when Tang Zui heard that Xu Qingzhu was actually only two years older than her, she was stunned.

"Other people's twenties: dating and getting married." Tang Zui wailed: "My twenties: single and lonely."

Qi Tang stuffed some food into her mouth: "Just eat more."

Days like these could be considered smooth.

But Liang Shi always worried about Xu Qingzhu. Once, she woke up in the middle of the night and saw Xu Qingzhu staring at her intently.

It gave her quite a fright.

Xu Qingzhu only said eerily: "I dreamed that you killed me."

Liang Shi reassured her that it wouldn't happen, but Xu Qingzhu cried sadly in her arms.

While crying, Xu Qingzhu said: "Wife, if one day you really point a knife at me, don't feel guilty."

Liang Shi's heart softened completely.

Liang Shi told her: "Even if you pointed a knife at me, I would never point one at you."

She said she stood by her words—even if she only had one knife in her hand, she would definitely hand the handle to Xu Qingzhu and point the blade at herself.

The two of them discussed this very seriously for a long time, before finally saying in a daze: "Why are we even discussing this kind of thing? Isn't it good to just live well? Let's also live well."

Apart from that time, nothing so heartbreaking happened again.

Footnotes:

1. "Buddha statue/zen" (佛系): A popular Chinese internet slang describing someone who is very laid-back, detached, and doesn't actively pursue things—going with the flow and not getting worked up about anything.

Chapter 155-4

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When the filming of "Mo Xin Tu Mo"¹ was halfway through, all the scenes in the mansion had been completed, and the entire crew changed locations to the city outskirts, where there was a place specifically for filming Republic era² dramas.

After changing locations, it was too far from Xu Qingzhu's company, and Liang Shi's scenes would wrap up in just one more week.

So Xu Qingzhu went back home to stay.

The days on set were very ordinary, just like many days before.

Gu Yixue would arrange everything in an orderly manner, putting in the most effort.

Fortunately, all the staff had been trained and tempered by Gu Yixue. They could understand what Gu Yixue wanted with just a single glance.

Being able to cultivate such rapport was truly rare.

However, it was visibly obvious that Gu Yixue was smoking more and more frequently.

Before filming started, Gu Yixue wasn't so dependent on cigarettes. The further into filming they got, the greater the pressure became—one pack a day was considered little.

If there were many scenes to film and the days were long, she would concentrate her smoking at night.

Liang Shi had seen her many times.

She would stand alone in a corner, like a phantom of the night, her figure lonely and desolate.

Facing the wall, she would light a cigarette, smoke it unhurriedly, then throw the cigarette butt into the trash can.

Afraid others would smell it, she would take out perfume and spray some on her sleeve cuffs.

Later, Liang Shi would invite her to eat late-night snacks, but Gu Yixue would drink and smoke at the same time.

Though she smoked less.

Liang Shi asked her what was troubling her.

Gu Yixue paused. At first, she answered that it was the pressure.

Later, when she had drunk too much, she said somewhat incoherently: "An annoying pest is coming."

When drunk, Gu Yixue had no defenses up, though her gaze remained cold.

Liang Shi helped her back to the hotel, then returned to her own room.

Where Liang Shi couldn't see, Sun Chengcheng hid in a corner and took a photo.

Staring at the photo on her phone, Sun Chengcheng quickly returned to her room.

The annoying pest Gu Yixue mentioned soon arrived at the crew. At first, Liang Shi didn't know—she was rehearsing with Qi Tang at the time, discussing how to act the next scene.

Then she saw someone standing there gracefully asking: "Is Director Gu Yixue here?"

Gu Yixue was holding the script in her hand. She glanced at her once before looking away.

The newcomer wore a moon-white qipao^3^ with a white long coat on the outside. On her wrist was a jade bangle, translucent throughout—it looked quite valuable.

Her arrival pressed a pause button on the entire crew; everyone looked over in unison.

"Continue." Gu Yixue said coldly, and only then did everyone resume working.

Gu Yixue stood up and walked over, handing the script she had been flipping through to her. She said flatly: "Not many lines, just one dance. You can do it, right?"

The other person nodded: "Yes."

When she smiled, she had a dimple, looking dignified and elegant, gentle and amiable.

Qi Tang couldn't help but look a few more times. Liang Shi had to call her several times to bring her soul back. "What are you doing?"

Qi Tang giggled: "Sorry, Teacher Liang."

"It's fine." Liang Shi also glanced at that person and guessed: "This should be the actress responsible for performing the water sleeve dance."

Qi Tang nodded: "Probably. You can tell from her figure that she can dance."

She paused mid-sentence. "But it feels like Director Gu really doesn't like her."

"It's alright," Liang Shi said. "Doesn't Director Gu always have that expression?"

Just then, Gu Yixue came over. Qi Tang immediately stopped talking, like an elementary school student caught badmouthing someone by their homeroom teacher.

Gu Yixue didn't speak much with that person and didn't even arrange anything for her. She directly called Liang Shi and Qi Tang to perform the next scene.

All the crew members returned to their positions and continued filming.

It wasn't until the morning scenes were finished and it was lunch break that Gu Yixue went to talk to that person.

But her expression still wasn't good. She only said two or three sentences before leaving to smoke.

Liang Shi grabbed an extra boxed meal and went to find Gu Yixue, handing it to her.

Gu Yixue glanced at her: "What?"

"You can't eat cigarettes for meals." Liang Shi pushed the boxed meal toward her. "You won't live long like this."

Gu Yixue: "..."

She stubbed out her cigarette and waved her hand to disperse the smoke. "If I only heard the first half of what you said, I'd think you liked me."

Liang Shi was stunned: "?"

Gu Yixue took the boxed meal. "Just joking."

Liang Shi let out a breath of relief. "You scared me."

"You and your wife have such a good relationship." Gu Yixue smiled lightly. "I wouldn't go so far as to break you two up."

Liang Shi: "..."

Occasionally when Xu Qingzhu was mentioned, Liang Shi felt a bit embarrassed.

But her heart was quite sweet.

The two of them found a random place to sit, unwrapped their chopsticks, and ate the boxed meals.

Gu Yixue pushed the rice and vegetables around in the box several times back and forth, but only ate a few bites.

Footnotes:

1. "Mo Xin Tu Mo" (心途): The title of the drama being filmed. It can be translated as "Journey of the Heart" or "Heart's Path."
2. Republic era (民國): Refers to the Republic of China period (1912-1949), a popular setting for Chinese historical dramas featuring the early modern period of Chinese history.
3. Qipao (旗袍): A traditional Chinese dress also known as cheongsam, characterized by a high collar, fitted waist, and side slits. It became particularly fashionable during the Republic era.

Chapter 155-5

Liang Shi watched from the side, frowning. "Are you like this whenever you start filming?"

Gu Yixue nodded: "Mm, too tired. Don't really feel like eating."

Liang Shi: "..."

"You've lost a lot more weight compared to when we first started filming." Liang Shi said: "Really, you can't get any thinner."

Hearing this, Gu Yixue smiled. "What? Is losing weight rapidly against the law?"

"Well, not exactly." Liang Shi said: "Being too thin or too fat both make you prone to illness."

"With this body of mine, the sooner I die, the sooner it's over." Gu Yixue didn't seem offended. She spoke about life and death in a casual, carefree manner. This reminded Liang Shi of Chen Mian, and she suddenly asked: "Are all genius artists like you very..."

Liang Shi paused, racking her brain for the right adjective. In the end, all she could think of was: "Crazy?"

Gu Yixue: "Hm?"

"Don't compare me to Qin Lishuang." Gu Yixue thought she was talking about Qin Lishuang and immediately distanced herself: "We're not the same kind of person."

Liang Shi shook her head: "Not Qin Lishuang. It's... Chen Mian. Do you know her? She's also a painter, a very talented artist. She's a little bit like you."

Gu Yixue paused briefly. "I've seen her paintings."

"But you know her?" Gu Yixue smiled. "I was just worrying about how to contact her. Are you two close?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Fairly close, I guess?" Liang Shi said: "At least I have her contact information."

"I want to ask her to paint something for the opening and ending scenes of the film. It would also be used as a backdrop in the movie." Gu Yixue said: "Help me ask if she's willing to paint it. The price is negotiable."

Liang Shi: "..."

Gu Yixue didn't push her. She just said: "If it puts you in a difficult position, I'll find her myself. I have some friends in the industry. It's just that I heard she doesn't like being in the spotlight and only paints when she feels like it."

Liang Shi: "It's fine, I'll ask her."

Speaking of Chen Mian, Gu Yixue suddenly said: "Why do people say artists shouldn't be too rich? Back then, Chen Mian's breakthrough piece sold for twenty million, and from then on she became willful. She doesn't care at all how much money people offer for her paintings—everything depends on whether she likes them at first sight."

"That's true." Liang Shi said: "She is quite willful, but she's also quite easy to talk to."

At least for Liang Shi, that was the case.

Liang Shi messaged Chen Mian with the specific requirements but didn't mention she was filming with Gu Yixue. She only said "our director," and Chen Mian asked who the director was.

Liang Shi replied: [Gu Yixue.]

Then Chen Mian video-called her.

Liang Shi was shocked and immediately answered.

Gu Yixue casually leaned over and waved. "Hello."

Chen Mian glanced at the camera and got straight to the point: "What do you want me to paint?"

Gu Yixue asked tentatively: "Meet up to discuss? I'll treat you to drinks."

Chen Mian thought for a moment. "Okay, tonight?"

Gu Yixue: "Sure."

In less than a minute, a major matter was settled.

Then, with Chen Mian's consent, Liang Shi shared Chen Mian's contact information with Gu Yixue.

Their work efficiency left Liang Shi dumbfounded.

Gu Yixue was amused by her expression. "What? Never seen such a fast collaboration?"

Liang Shi nodded: "It's just... do geniuses communicate through brain waves?"

Gu Yixue: "..."

"Little sister, how are you so cute?" Gu Yixue genuinely laughed, her brows and eyes tinged with relaxation. It had been many days since anyone had seen such an expression on her. Liang Shi was also infected by this ease.

Liang Shi said sincerely: "I thought you would at least discuss each other's compensation, style, and such. I didn't expect you could just directly arrange to have drinks."

"Whether someone is suitable for collaboration—you can tell at a glance." Gu Yixue also answered her sincerely: "I've seen her paintings, she's seen my films, so we hit it off immediately."

"Looks like even without me, you two could have made it work." Liang Shi said: "I was just a connecting thread."

"No, you're also very important." Gu Yixue said: "This thread of yours saved us a lot of trouble. I'll give you a 1% cut when the time comes."

"Then how much can you offer Chen Mian?"

Gu Yixue paused: "Depends on what she wants. She might just ask me to treat her to drinks."

Liang Shi: "..."

So feelings were all lies.

The two of them ate and chatted casually. Just when they were having a good time, a cold and overbearing voice came through: "Where's Gu Yixue? She's letting you eat this kind of stuff? Where is she?"

Just as the voice fell, Gu Yixue's phone started ringing.

Gu Yixue looked at the food she had only taken a few bites of—she hadn't even finished the portion piled on top.

Liang Shi quickly shoveled a few more bites of rice, then stood up to follow. She casually asked: "Who is it?"

"Trash attracted another piece of trash." Gu Yixue said as she dismissed the call, and the ringing finally stopped. Then she walked over in that direction.

That person had a baby face and wasn't very tall. She stood next to the woman in the qipao who had come that morning, saying with a face full of distress: "This isn't fit for human consumption. Why are you eating this? Gu Yixue must have done this on purpose."

The moment Gu Yixue was mentioned, she became filled with righteous indignation.

"Would I bother?" Gu Yixue hadn't even walked over yet when she heard this and spoke coldly.

"Gu Yixue." The baby-faced woman glared viciously at Gu Yixue: "I told you to take good care of Wenwen. Is this how you treat her? If you have a problem with me, come at me directly. Don't secretly trip me up. I look down on this kind of behavior the most."

"Everyone eats the same thing." Gu Yixue said: "She wanted to act in my production, so she has to follow my rules. There are so many people here, and I eat the same food. How is it not fit for human consumption? Everyone else can eat it, but only your Wenwen can't? Then take her away. What's the point of this?"

"Stop acting like a saint after being a whore." Gu Yixue scoffed, her eyes ice-cold. "If you want to cause trouble on my set..."

"What are you going to do?" Before she could finish, the baby-faced woman interrupted and mocked: "Gu Yixue, have you gotten too bold? Don't think that just because you've grown up, you're no longer surnamed Gu."

"So what?" Gu Yixue asked calmly in return.

This actually stumped the baby-faced woman.

Everyone present fell silent, not daring to breathe loudly.

It seemed like everyone was waiting for the drama to unfold.

Then Gu Yixue concluded: "If she can act, she acts. If she can't, take her back early. You've been keeping her for so long anyway; you won't mind a few more years."

Before her words even finished, the baby-faced woman's fist swung toward her, but Gu Yixue grabbed it tightly, rendering it immobile.

Gu Yixue looked at her lazily and said coldly: "Gu Chunmian, do you still think I'm the Gu Yixue from twenty years ago?"

Although Gu Yixue was thin, she was also quite strong.

Sun Chengcheng, standing to the side, immediately recalled Gu Yixue's profile introduction upon hearing this name.

The person she hated the most—Gu Chunmian.

But the current situation didn't allow her to do anything; she could only stay quiet.

Footnotes:

1. "Acting like a saint after being a whore" (當了婊子又立牌坊): A crude Chinese idiom meaning to act virtuously or self-righteously while having done something shameful or hypocritical. It describes someone who pretends to be innocent or moral despite their questionable actions.

Chapter 155-6

Gu Chunmian confronted Gu Yixue. Her face turned a fierce red, yet she still couldn't break free from Gu Yixue's grip. Feeling both vexed and angry, she threatened: "Gu Yixue, if you keep this up, I'll have you thrown out."

"How old are you to still be playing these games?" Gu Yixue sneered, pressing her fingers on Gu Chunmian's hand bones. "Gu Chunmian, do I need to remind you? I moved out of the Gu family many years ago."

"There's still your family registry." Gu Chunmian said: "And your mother's. Wasn't your mother's dying wish to be added to our Gu family's genealogy? Do you want her dying wish to go unfulfilled?"

This struck Gu Yixue's soft spot, and she suddenly loosened her grip.

Gu Chunmian, in her fury, raised her hand to swing at Gu Yixue's face.

Her hand was stopped just a hair's breadth away.

Liang Shi stood in front of Gu Yixue. In the end, she couldn't help but intervene. She grabbed Gu Chunmian's wrist. "Miss, this is a film set. Please have some self-respect."

"Who are you?" Gu Chunmian said: "Is our family's business any of your concern?"

"But this is a film set." Liang Shi said: "Not your home."

Gu Chunmian was stunned: "Who exactly are you?"

Then she looked at her with great impatience and suddenly frowned: "What the hell."

Gu Yixue shook her wrist, about to call Liang Shi away, when she heard Gu Chunmian say in shock: "Gu Yixue, have you no shame? You fucking found a substitute modeled after my wife?"

The moment these words came out, the entire crew was in an uproar.

Liang Shi was also stunned. "What are you talking about?"

Gu Chunmian gritted her teeth. "This face looks way too similar to that dead woman Shen Fenghe."

"Especially the eyes." Gu Chunmian stared at Liang Shi's eyes, practically breathing fire, and burst out cursing: "Gu Yixue, have you no shame? Your mother was just a mistress, and now you even want your sister's woman..."

Slap—

Gu Chunmian's indignation and agitation were scattered in a slap.

Yet her arm was still restrained by Liang Shi.

And it wasn't just one person who slapped her.

A woman wearing a black coat with a white shirt underneath had a tall figure. Standing there, she was about the same height as Liang Shi. Her steps were somewhat hurried, but when she slapped Gu Chunmian, she showed no mercy.

One slap swung up, directly silencing Gu Chunmian.

Gu Yixue's slap came after, also with full force, but it landed on the other person's hand instead.

It directly turned her hand red.

Gu Yixue sheepishly stepped back half a pace and called out obediently and pitifully: "Sister Fenghe."

Completely different from the usual Gu Yixue—she looked like a pitiful thing that had been bullied.

Liang Shi took the opportunity to release Gu Chunmian's wrist and stepped back half a pace.

Gu Yixue called the assistant director to clear the set.

A crowd of onlookers dispersed in droves.

Liang Shi also wanted to leave, eager to escape from this scandal, but then she heard Gu Yixue say: "You shouldn't leave either. After all, they're calling you a substitute."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi couldn't help but retort: "Is spreading rumors not against the law?"

It took Gu Chunmian a long time to come back to her senses. She raised her head to look at Shen Fenghe.

The other woman stood like a straight poplar tree, looking down at her condescendingly. Her voice was cold and sharp: "Gu Chunmian, have you embarrassed yourself enough?"

Gu Chunmian was stunned: "You hit me?"

Shen Fenghe scoffed: "If I didn't hit you, what would that make me? You have no shame yourself, so don't drag me down to your level. Isn't it disgusting?"

When she said the last part, Shen Fenghe's gaze coldly turned toward the woman in the qipao standing to the side.

"Normally, you don't say a single word to Gu Yixue." Shen Fenghe said: "So why are you stuffing someone into her crew now? You just think she's easy to bully, right?"

Gu Chunmian was dumbfounded.

Who's easy to bully?

Gu Yixue?

That's a fucking wolf in sheep's clothing!

Gu Chunmian gritted her teeth: "Bullshit! You think I don't know about the thing between you and Gu Yixue? She even called your name when she was drunk before..."

"That was one-sided on my part." Gu Yixue immediately said: "Sister Fenghe didn't know."

"So what if it was?" Shen Fenghe said: "How long have you been keeping her outside? You really think I don't know?"

Shen Fenghe looked at the qipao woman and walked over unhurriedly.

"Shen Fenghe!" Gu Chunmian immediately said: "What are you doing? Try laying a finger on Wenwen!"

"She's not worthy of me lifting a finger." Shen Fenghe had one hand in her coat pocket, her expression indifferent. Without any trace of disdain in her tone, she said: "A nobody."

"You!" Hearing her sweetheart being talked about like this, Gu Chunmian immediately became furious and stepped forward to argue with Shen Fenghe, but her sleeve was tugged.

Ye Ziwen, with reddened eyes, said quietly: "Mianmian, stop arguing. Let's go."

Gu Chunmian looked even more distressed. "It's okay, Wenwen. No one can talk about you like that."

Ye Ziwen said: "There's no need. It's not worth it for my sake."

Gu Chunmian was so moved that tears welled up in her eyes. "It's worth it. You're definitely worth it."

The two of them were being lovey-dovey here as if no one else existed, making even Liang Shi, an outsider, feel a bit awkward.

Who knew what the other two involved parties were feeling.

"I can't watch this anymore." Kong Xiaoxiao, who had come with Shen Fenghe, couldn't help it. "Gu Chunmian, are you crazy? Do you really think this nobody can marry you? If it really doesn't work out, just break off the engagement. We all grew up together—what kind of palace intrigue are you playing at?"^2^

Gu Chunmian paused: "What business is it of yours?"

Shen Fenghe stopped Kong Xiaoxiao: "Don't get worked up."

Kong Xiaoxiao glanced at her.

Then she heard Shen Fenghe say: "Gu Chunmian, I'll give you two choices. One, break things off with her within ten days, and we'll get our marriage certificate and hold the wedding. Two, go tell the Gu family within ten days that you want to break off the engagement, and our betrothal will be canceled. If I don't receive news of you breaking off the engagement after ten days, then I'll hold the wedding."

"If you don't show up that day, I'll grab a dog from the street and hold the wedding anyway." Shen Fenghe said: "Also, if you say one thing and do another—if you marry me but keep this woman on the side—I don't mind sending her abroad, somewhere you'll never find in your lifetime."

Gu Chunmian was shocked. "You!"

"You know me." Shen Fenghe said: "I keep my word."

"Shen Fenghe! You're forcing me!" Gu Chunmian shrieked. That cute baby face now looked somewhat ferocious.

Shen Fenghe said: "There's no building without breaking. Besides, you should understand—without me, you can't get the Gu family's inheritance rights."

After saying this, she called to Gu Yixue: "Let's go eat."

Gu Yixue responded blankly: "Oh."

Then she pulled Liang Shi along and left.

Footnotes:

1. Family registry/genealogy (族譜): A traditional Chinese family record book that documents the lineage, ancestors, and members of a family clan. Being included in a family's genealogy is significant as it represents official recognition as a family member and legitimacy within the clan.
2. "Palace intrigue" (宮心計): A reference to scheming and manipulation typically seen in historical Chinese palace dramas. Kong Xiaoxiao is sarcastically asking why Gu Chunmian is creating unnecessary drama and complications like a character in a palace drama.

Chapter 155-7

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The group of them walked to a restaurant. Kong Xiaoxiao was still angry, continuously complaining about Gu Chunmian's terrible behavior, then looked at Gu Yixue with distress.

She even advised her: "Don't indulge her too much. You don't rely on the Gu family anymore anyway, so why bother with her?"

Gu Yixue smiled bitterly: "My mother's name is still in the Gu family genealogy."

Putting on a weak and pitiful act.

Liang Shi glanced at Gu Yixue, then at Shen Fenghe.

She seemed to understand something.

Meanwhile, Shen Fenghe was staring at her intently.

Being stared at made Liang Shi a bit flustered. She touched her chin: "Um... Miss Shen, you shouldn't... have any misunderstanding, right? There's nothing between Director Gu and me."

Liang Shi said: "I'm married. We're purely colleagues and friends."

"I know." Shen Fenghe lowered her eyelashes. The teacup emanating misty steam continuously released the fragrance of tea.

Shen Fenghe's voice was no longer as cold as before. She said lightly: "It's just that everyone says we look alike, so I looked at you a few more times. I apologize for the offense."

"Ah..." Liang Shi nodded: "Alright."

But Gu Yixue looked over. "I don't think you two look that alike."

"That's because you have a filter for Shen Fenghe." Kong Xiaoxiao teased. "You're Shen Fenghe's little fangirl, so of course you think no one in the world looks like Shen Fenghe. No one is as good-looking as your Sister Fenghe."

Gu Yixue lowered her head: "Sister Xiaoxiao, please don't tease me. Things will really become unclear later."

"Just joking." Kong Xiaoxiao laughed: "Seriously though, the two of them really do look alike—the eyes and nose and everything."

Hearing this, Shen Fenghe rarely joked: "If my younger sister hadn't passed away, I'd definitely think you were my sister."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Passed away?" Liang Shi paused for a moment, then suddenly asked: "Are you Shen Hui and Shen Siyan's older sister?"

Shen Fenghe paused: "You know them?"

Liang Shi: "..."

What a coincidence.

Liang Shi smiled: "I had the fortune of meeting Dr. Shen before, and I've also met your younger brother once."

She put it tactfully.

But Shen Fenghe said: "That's quite a coincidence."

Kong Xiaoxiao rested her chin on her hand. "So no one has ever said you look like Siyan? You're basically like a gender-swapped version."

Liang Shi: "...Someone has said our eyes look very similar."

It was Zhao Xuning's cousin Zhao Ling who had said it back then.

At the time, Liang Shi had looked for quite a while and just thought their eyes were beautiful and quite unique, and also felt somewhat familiar.

It was only after she mentioned it that Zhao Ling pointed it out.

"That's right." Kong Xiaoxiao said: "In all my years, the only people I've seen with this eye color are from their family, because their father has eyes like that. As for others... I've seen similar ones, but never this similar. If their family hadn't never lost a child, I'd suspect you were their long-lost little sister."

Liang Shi: "..."

Kong Xiaoxiao said this while nudging Shen Fenghe. "Seriously, don't you want to go back and ask your dad?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Shen Fenghe glanced at her. "You never say anything serious."

But Kong Xiaoxiao's words made Liang Shi suspicious. She pressed her lips together and, while eating, pretended to ask casually: "Miss Shen, how old was your younger sister who passed away when she died?"

"One month old." Shen Fenghe said: "A premature baby. She stayed in an incubator the whole time but didn't make it. Why?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "Nothing, just asking."

Kong Xiaoxiao teased: "Are you really suspecting you might be a child from their family?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Saying it like that made it feel like she was reaching above her station. Liang Shi shook her head: "No, just asking casually."

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After the midday drama with Gu Chunmian ended, everyone thought her white moonlight¹ Ye Ziwen would leave. Unexpectedly, she stubbornly stayed with the crew.

It was Gu Chunmian who left instead.

Without Gu Chunmian around, Gu Yixue wouldn't go out of her way to make things difficult for Ye Ziwen.

After all, it was just two scenes.

It's just that Ye Ziwen kept sitting there looking dejected.

No one in the crew dared to provoke her.

The afternoon scenes were wrapped up hastily. Gu Yixue had an appointment with Chen Mian that evening, so everyone got off work early.

Liang Shi felt it was still early, and she didn't want to be an ordinary person sandwiched between the two geniuses Gu Yixue and Chen Mian. So after wrapping up, she said goodbye to Gu Yixue and drove back to the city.

As it happened, Gu Yixue and Chen Mian had also arranged to meet in the city. Not wanting to drive herself, Gu Yixue hitched a ride with Liang Shi.

Liang Shi dropped Gu Yixue off at the destination, then went around a block to reach Xu Qingzhu's company.

It was already dark.

She didn't ask Xu Qingzhu whether she was working overtime; she just came straight over.

Wanting to give her a surprise.

Coincidentally, just as Liang Shi arrived downstairs, the bitter winter wind blew against her body, stinging every inch of her skin.

Just as she was about to go in, she saw Xu Qingzhu walking out.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a light-colored coat, and coming out with her was... Lu Jiayi.

Lu Jiayi was also in light colors, with a faint smile on her face, helping hold the door.

The two were chatting about something. Xu Qingzhu laughed—a genuine, proper laugh, not the perfunctory, cold smile she wore in business settings.

They seemed to be having a great conversation.

Liang Shi stood there and suddenly felt like she was a bit redundant.

She even had a thought: I shouldn't have come, right?

She even instinctively turned around, afraid Xu Qingzhu would see her.

But after a few seconds, she turned back.

—How could she avoid Xu Qingzhu like this?

The moment she turned back, she was suddenly pulled into a full embrace.

Liang Shi was stunned.

Xu Qingzhu, not caring that they were on a street with people coming and going, tightened her arms around her. "Wife, why are you here?"

Liang Shi: "...You were chatting so happily with someone, yet you still noticed me?"

There was a hint of jealousy in her words.

Xu Qingzhu nestled in her arms and nuzzled her. "We were just talking about you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly: "Miss Lu was praising you for being very articulate."

Liang Shi: "?"

Seriously?

Footnotes:

1. White moonlight (白月光): A Chinese internet slang term referring to an idealized first love or an unreachable, pure love interest that one can never forget. It represents someone who is perfect in one's memory—beautiful, unattainable, and forever cherished.